Q23 Comprehension Check

Question: An agent repeatedly calls the same tool with identical arguments, gets an error each time, and eventually exhausts its turn budget. Your teammate says: "The model is broken — it keeps retrying a failing call." Give the three-way attribution analysis: what evidence would distinguish a model failure from an instruction failure from a harness failure here, and which single instrument from the module (logging, replay, or ablation) would you apply first?

Answer: The behavior is a retry storm, and the module's default suspicion is harness cause, not model cause — but the evidence must rule the layers in or out. *Model failure* would show the model choosing an identical retry despite an error message that already contained the fix (check the logged context: was the needed information present?). *Instruction failure* would show the prompt telling the model to "keep trying until it works" or never specifying a fallback (check the system prompt and task spec). *Harness failure* would show an uninformative error surface ("error" with no cause), or a timeout firing just before the slow tool succeeds, converting would-be successes into error+retry cycles (check raw tool results vs. what was injected, and per-call timing). Apply **logging first**: it is the cheapest instrument, it is a prerequisite for the other two, and here it immediately separates the hypotheses — if the error text reaching the model carried no actionable information, the harness's error surface is the cause and the "dumb model" reading is an artifact of harness design.